Countable and uncountable nouns

Nombre: _____ Fecha: _____

Qué vas a aprender

- Tell the difference between countable and uncountable nouns
- Use a / an, some and any correctly
- Ask about quantity with How many...? and How much...?
- Use containers to count uncountable things: a bottle of, a piece of

Para pensar

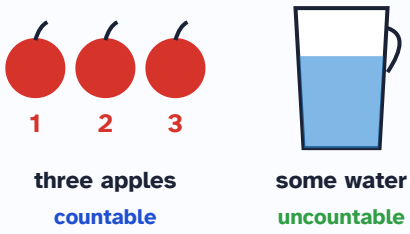
Puedes decir «three apples» (tres manzanas), pero ¿puedes decir «three waters» o «three breads»? ¿Por qué?

Explicación

Countable or uncountable?

Countable nouns are things we can count one by one: an apple, two apples; a chair, three chairs; a friend, ten friends. They have a **singular** and a **plural** form.

Uncountable nouns are things we can't count one by one, like liquids, materials and some foods: water, milk, juice, rice, sugar, bread, cheese, money, music, homework. They have **no plural**: we never say «rices» or «musics». **En castellano:** pasa algo parecido con «arroz» o «leche»; no decimos «tres arroces».



Countable: singular and plural

With singular countable nouns we use a or an: **a** banana, **a** sandwich, **an** egg, **an** orange (an before a vowel sound). We can't say just «I want banana»: we need *a*.

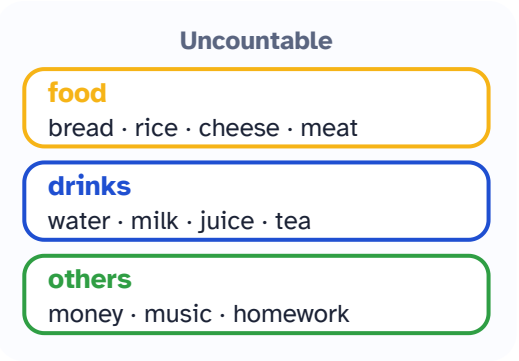
Plurals usually add **-s**: apples, carrots. After -s, -sh, -ch, -x and some -o words add **-es**: glasses, sandwiches, potatoes, tomatoes. Consonant + y → **-ies**: strawberry → strawberries, cherry → cherries. Irregular: child → children, person → people, foot → feet, tooth → teeth, mouse → mice.

Singular	Plural
an apple	apples
a tomato	tomatoes
a cherry	cherries
a child	children

Uncountable nouns

Uncountable nouns use the verb in **singular**: «The water **is** cold», «Rice **is** good for you», «My homework **is** difficult». We don't use *a* or *an* with them: not «a bread», but «**some** bread».

Common uncountable nouns: **food** (bread, rice, pasta, cheese, meat, butter, sugar, salt), **drinks** (water, milk, juice, tea), and also **money, time, music, information, homework, furniture, weather**. **En castellano:** ojo con *homework* o *furniture* (muebles), que en inglés no tienen plural.



Some and any

We use *some* in **affirmative** sentences, with plural countable nouns and with uncountable nouns: «There are **some** eggs», «I'd like **some** water».

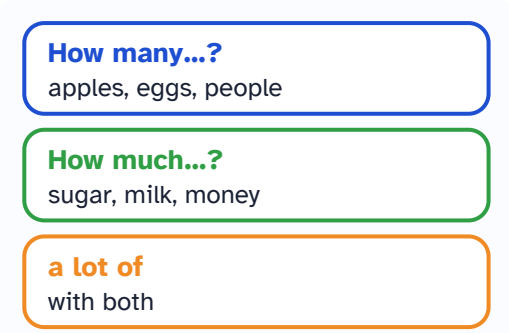
We use *any* in **negatives** and **questions**: «There aren't **any** eggs», «Is there **any** milk?». Exception: offers and requests use *some* in questions: «Would you like **some** cake?». **En castellano:** *some* es «algo de / algunos»; *any* en negativa es «nada de / ningún».

	Countable	Uncountable
+	some eggs	some milk
–	any eggs	any milk
?	any eggs?	any milk?

How many? How much?

To ask about quantity: How many...? with **plural countable** nouns and How much...? with **uncountable** nouns. «**How many** apples do we need?» – «Six». «**How much** sugar do we need?» – «A little» / «200 grams».

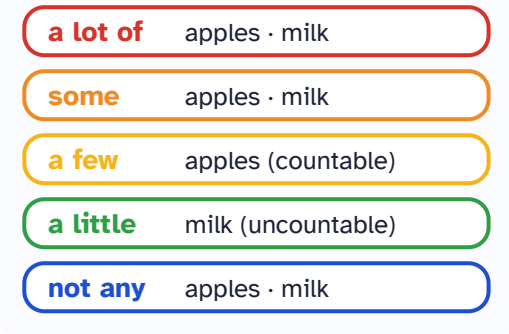
In the same way: **many** (muchos) with countable and **much** (mucho) with uncountable in negatives and questions: «There aren't **many** people», «I haven't got **much** time». **A lot of** goes with both: «**a lot of** friends», «**a lot of** water».



A few and a little

For a **small quantity** we say a few with countable nouns and a little with uncountable nouns: «I've got **a few** friends in Madrid», «Can I have **a little** milk in my tea?».

From most to least: **a lot of** → **some** → **a few / a little** → **not any / no**. **En castellano:** *a few* es «unos pocos» y *a little* es «un poco de». Fíjate en que el inglés distingue si se puede contar o no, y el español casi nunca.



Containers and pieces

To count uncountable things we use containers (recipientes) or portions: **a bottle of** water, **a glass of** milk, **a cup of** tea, **a carton of** juice, **a packet of** rice,

a jar of honey, **a can of** lemonade.

Portions: **a piece of** cake, **a slice of** bread / pizza / cheese, **a bar of** chocolate, **a kilo of** meat, **a loaf of** bread (una barra). The container is countable: «two bottles **of** water», «three slices **of** pizza».

Container	Food
a bottle of	water
a slice of	pizza
a carton of	juice
a bar of	chocolate

Reading: a shopping list

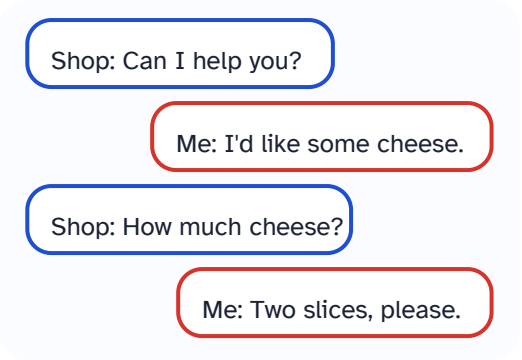
Read the dialogue in the kitchen: «Mum: We're going to make pancakes. **How many** eggs have we got? Dani: There are **a few**, only two. Mum: We need three. And **how much** milk is there? Dani: There's **a little**, half a carton. Mum: OK, let's write a list: six eggs, **a carton of** milk and **a bag of** flour. Is there **any** sugar? Dani: Yes, there's **a lot of** sugar. And can we buy **some** strawberries? Mum: Of course!»



Let's practise: at the market

Role-play in pairs: one is the shop assistant and the other is the customer. «Good morning! Can I help you?» – «Yes, please. I'd like **a kilo of** tomatoes and **some** cheese.» – «**How much** cheese?» – «**Two slices**, please.» – «Anything else?» – «Have you got **any** bananas?» – «Sorry, there aren't **any**.»

Consejo: antes de preguntar, piensa: ¿se puede contar? Si sí, *How many*; si no, *How much*.



Countable and uncountable

countable	uncountable	small amount	counting
APPLES	**WATER**	**A FEW**	**A BOTTLE OF**
a / an / some How many?	some / any How much?	a little (uncountable)	a slice of a piece of

Ejercicios

1. **Write the plural: potato, strawberry, box, foot.**

2. **Countable or uncountable? milk, chair, money, sandwich.**

3. **Complete with a or an: ___ orange, ___ banana, ___ egg.**

4. **Complete with some or any: «Have you got ___ brothers?»**

5. **Complete: «How ___ people were there?»**

6. **Complete: «Can I have a ___ of pizza?»**

7. **Complete with a few or a little: «I've got ___ friends in Bilbao.»**

8. **Correct: «I need an information.»**

9. **Translate: «¿Cuánta agua hay?»**

10. **Write your breakfast with quantities.**

Practica

1. **Which noun is uncountable?**
   - **A)** apple
   - **B)** rice
   - **C)** chair
2. **«___ egg»**
   - **A)** a
   - **B)** some
   - **C)** an
3. **«How ___ sugar do you want?»**
   - **A)** much
   - **B)** many
   - **C)** a few
4. **«How ___ friends have you got?»**
   - **A)** much
   - **B)** a little
   - **C)** many
5. **«There aren't ___ biscuits.»**
   - **A)** some
   - **B)** any
   - **C)** a
6. **«Would you like ___ cake?»**
   - **A)** some
   - **B)** any
   - **C)** many
7. **The plural of «child» is...**
   - **A)** childs
   - **B)** children
   - **C)** childrens
8. **«a ___ of water»**
   - **A)** slice

B) bar

C) bottle

9. **«I've got ___ money.» (un poco)**

A) a little

B) a few

C) many

10. **Which sentence is correct?**

A) My homeworks are easy.

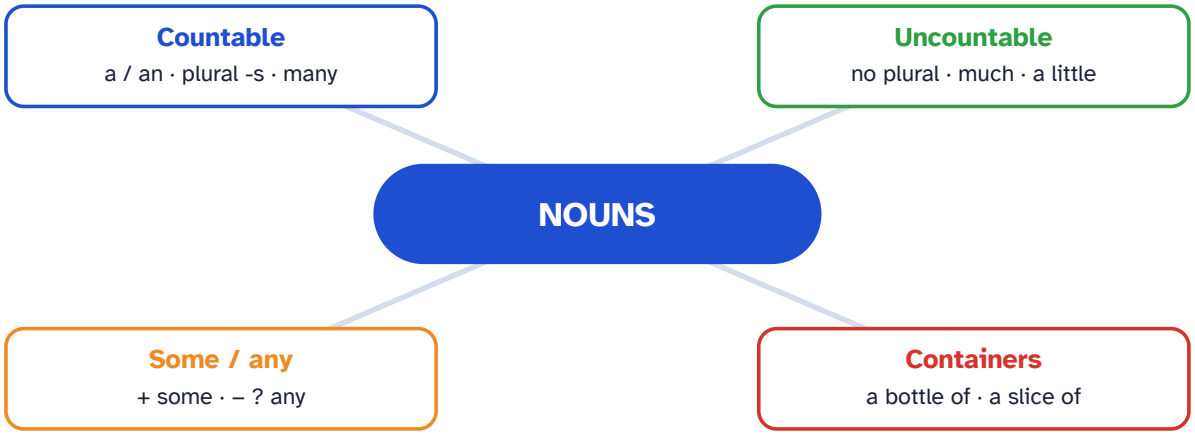
B) My homework is easy.

C) My homework are easy.

Explícalo con tus palabras

Incluye: Qué es un nombre contable y uno incontable; Cuándo se usa some y cuándo any; Diferencia entre How many y How much; Cómo se cuentan los incontables con recipientes y porciones.

Resumen



Tarjetas de repaso

Recórtalas: pregunta delante, respuesta detrás.

Countable

Se cuenta: an apple, two apples.

Uncountable

No se cuenta: water, rice, money.

some

Afirmativas y ofrecimientos.

any

Negativas y preguntas.

How many…?

¿Cuántos? (contables).

How much…?

¿Cuánto? (incontables).

a few / a little

Unos pocos / un poco de.

a slice of

Una loncha o porción de.

Soluciones

1. **B)** No se cuenta uno a uno.
2. **C)** Sonido vocálico: an.
3. **A)** Sugar: incontable.
4. **C)** Friends: contable plural.
5. **B)** Negativa: any.
6. **A)** Ofrecimiento: some.
7. **B)** Irregular.
8. **C)** Recipiente para líquidos.
9. **A)** Money: incontable.
10. **B)** Homework es incontable.

Soluciones de los ejercicios

1. potatoes, strawberries, boxes, feet.
2. Uncountable: milk, money. Countable: chair, sandwich.
3. an orange, a banana, an egg.
4. any.
5. many.
6. slice (o piece).
7. a few.
8. I need some information.
9. How much water is there?
10. Model answer: I have a glass of milk, two biscuits and a piece of fruit.